

Literature Review — Synthesis, Not Summary

Building a critical argument from the existing scholarship

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A literature review is a critical, structured analysis of the existing scholarship relevant to the research question. Its purpose is not to summarise each source in turn, but to synthesise across sources — comparing, contrasting and grouping them to reveal what is known, what is contested and where the gap lies that your study addresses. A strong review is organised by theme or debate, not by author, and builds toward a justified research gap (Hart, 2018).

SUMMARY (weak)

Describes each source one after another: 'Smith says X. Jones says Y. Lee says Z.' The reader learns what each author wrote but not how they relate. This is an annotated bibliography, not a review — and it is a frequent examiner criticism.

SYNTHESIS (strong)

Organises by idea and shows relationships: 'Two positions dominate the debate on X. One holds... (Smith, 2019; Lee, 2021); the other counters... (Jones, 2020). Neither addresses..., which this study examines.' Sources are in conversation.

The gap is the point. The whole review builds toward the space your research fills — an under-studied population, an unresolved contradiction, a theory untested in your context. If the reader cannot state your research gap after reading the review, it has not done its job. Make the gap explicit.

Move	Summary	Synthesis
Organised by	Author	Theme / debate
Sources	Listed in turn	In conversation
Voice	Descriptive	Critical, evaluative
Ends with	A list	A justified gap

GROUP BY THEME

Cluster sources by the ideas they address, then compare within each cluster. Use theme headings, not author names, as your structure.

BE CRITICAL

Evaluate quality, method and limits of what you cite — don't take every claim at face value. Weigh the evidence.

LEAD TO THE GAP

Every strand should converge on the gap your study fills, giving your research questions their justification.

Common pitfalls. (1) An author-by-author summary with no synthesis. (2) No critical evaluation — everything reported as equally valid. (3) No clearly stated gap. (4) Outdated or non-scholarly sources dominating. (5) A review disconnected from the research questions.

REFERENCES

Hart, C. (2018) *Doing a Literature Review*. 2nd edn. London: SAGE. · Ridley, D. (2012) *The Literature Review: A Step-by-Step Guide for Students*. 2nd edn. London: SAGE. · Booth, A., Sutton, A. and Papaioannou, D. (2016) *Systematic Approaches to a Successful Literature Review*. 2nd edn. London: SAGE.